

Chile

 A long and extremely narrow country, Chile measures, at most, only about 430 km (267 miles) wide. Most Chileans live in cities and towns in the Central Valley, between the low coastal mountains to the west and the towering Andes on the east. The cold, stormy southern coast is flanked by thousands of islands, whose waters provide rich fishing grounds. Chile has a strong economy rooted in its natural resources: minerals, fruit, sea products, and timber.

Santiago

Located in the heart of Chile, the capital, Santiago, is a bustling, modern city. The city and suburbs house about five million people. Santiago is known for severe traffic congestion, and has one of the highest taxi densities in the world, with one per 100 inhabitants. About 3,600 km (2,236 miles) of Pan-American Highway runs through Santiago, but high smog levels over the city concern environmentalists.

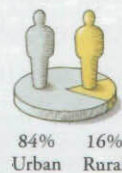


Some of Santiago's 14,500 buses on Avenue Campama



Mapuche

Descended from the original inhabitants of South America, the Mapuche people are also known as the Araucanians. About 675,000 Mapuche live in the central and southern regions of Chile. They follow the Roman Catholic religion and speak their own language, as well as Spanish. The Mapuche people have fought for independence since the 16th century and are still at odds with the Chilean government. Quechua and Aymara Indians also live in the country, in the north.



The Chuquicamata copper mine, 670 m (2,200 ft) deep



Copper

Chile leads the world in the production of copper ore, of which it owns about 20 per cent of known reserves. The Central Valley, which extends for 1,600 km (994 miles), has the world's largest underground copper mine, located at El Teniente. Chuquicamata, in the bleak Atacama Desert, is one of the largest open-cast copper mines in the world. The country also mines iron, gold, and silver.

Wine

Vineyards first planted by Spanish colonists in the 1500s have benefited from the hot, dry summers in the Central Valley. Today, about 320,000 tonnes (350,000 tons) of Chilean wines, red from Cabernet Sauvignon grapes and white from Chardonnay grapes, are exported all over the world.



CHILE FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Santiago
AREA	748,800 sq km (289,112 sq miles)
POPULATION	15,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Spanish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Chilean peso
LIFE EXPECTANCY	75 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	909
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	96%

Crabs are put into small baskets.



Fishing

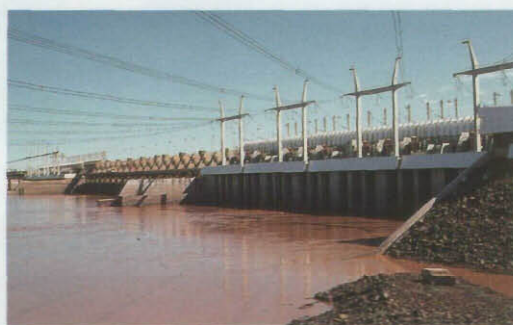
Although less than one per cent of the people work in the fishing industry, Chile leads the world in fishmeal production. In a good year, around 6,000 tonnes of sardines, anchovies, mackerel, and salmon are caught and processed. Punta Arenas, on the Strait of Magellan in the south, is the industry's centre.

Uruguay

 One of the smallest countries in South America, Uruguay is also one of the most prosperous and harmonious. More than 40 per cent of its people, about 1,449,900, live in Montevideo, the capital, chief port, and largest city. The rest are scattered over the vast lowland pastures. Uruguay has a high tourist rate, mainly because of its sandy beaches and fine weather.

People

There are 11 times as many sheep, cattle, and horses as people in Uruguay. Most Uruguayans are of Spanish or Italian descent. They enjoy considerable prosperity, largely due to the wealth from earlier cattle ranching in the country.



Hydroelectricity

More than 90 per cent of Uruguay's power is generated through hydroelectricity. The main hydroelectric plants are situated on the country's major rivers, the Uruguay and its tributary, the Río Negro, which both widen out into the Río de la Plata estuary. Huge turbines have been built across the rivers, so that as the water rushes through, it turns the turbines and makes electricity.



Hand-made scarf

URUGUAY FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Montevideo
AREA	174,810 sq km (67,494 sq miles)
POPULATION	3,300,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Spanish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Uruguayan peso

Wool

Three-quarters of Uruguay is rich, green pasture that provides excellent grazing land for its 25,000,000 sheep and 10,000,000 cattle.

The land provides work for nearly half the population. Uruguay is the world's second biggest producer of wool, and textiles made from wool account for about 20 per cent of Uruguayan exports.

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